In Vijayawada, during peak traffic hours, police officers place metal barricades on either side of a road. From what I've gathered, the primary purpose of said barricades is to narrow the road slightly to create a slight bottleneck in traffic thereby spacing out more evenly the cars on the road. I noticed them most clearly when my cousin looked up from his three phones just in time to swerve out of the way. He turned to me, said "Thanks, Villy, I didn't see that there," before continuing to "successfully" multitask.

We were coming from Bloomingdales, an international school on the outskirts of the city for rich kids, after playing a game of basketball. As the most seasoned player in the pickup league, I had the bizarre experience of also being the best. Which, for anyone who has seen me dribble the ball, speaks more to the state about basketball in Vijayawada than my ability to drive in the paint.

I've always loved sports. I grew up rushing through my math homework so I could watch Sunday Night Football with my dad. I did the dishes all summer long so my mom would send me to the University of Delaware's basketball camp. I sulked for a week when my parents kept me from joining the high school football team. In their defense, I was four feet and nine inches tall with the build of the Pilsbury doughboy. In my defense, my high school's mascot was a dancing calculator. I wasn't too concerned. In any case, my love for the game was undeniable.

I spent the last year realizing long deferred high school sports dreams. After five years in Mississippi, I moved to Beijing to study global affairs at Tsinghua University. At Tsinghua, there's a motto: "No Sports. No Tsinghua." Students are, at all times, running on the track, swimming, throwing a frisbee, playing pickleball, or moving their bodies. There's a vibrancy to campus that had me hooked, immediately. And now, as a respectable five feet and eight inches tall twenty-seven-year-old, I could compete.

My college's basketball team won the intramural championship for the first time. I learned I was a bad swimmer and got some help to get better. I co-captained the frisbee team, played backfield in soccer, bumped in volleyball, and danced in the basement with my friends. Sports were endless and exhilarating and serious and fun. I was experiencing, for the first time, what it felt like to win and lose and struggle with your team—and the pleasure of deepening bonds with those you cherish.

I graduated from my program and flew out of Beijing on June 30th to India for my cousin's wedding. I love visiting India. During our summer visits, my sister and I would play with our cousins endlessly and cry inconsolably when corralled onto the flight back to the U.S. I'm fortunate, too, that my parents raised my sister and I speaking Telugu at home. It makes our bonds with our family here that much deeper.

One might quickly notice that Vijayawada is not built for movement. Specifically, it's not built for the pedestrian. For the motorcycle, auto, rikshaws, car, cow, or exhaust spewing bus, sure, you'll be fine. But on your two feet? Good luck. Crossing the street requires near divine intervention (I'm blessed). More and more, we live in a world built for machines.

So, when my cousin asks me if I want to get in his car and drive an hour to play basketball, I grab my sneakers and a water bottle without any question.

It's rare for me to have social interactions with my family here without the constant interruption of technology. People here pick up the phone…all the time. It's a particular form of hell for my phone-anxious friends in the States. Picking up the phone takes primacy over the real, in-person interaction you are having with another human being. The phone is the default. My grandmother scrolls reels on Instagram after making her morning filter coffee, my uncle scrolls reels to learn about vegan ice cream production (he promises it will take off), and my cousin is yelling about an issue happening on the construction site or chatting with his soon-to-be fiancé over FaceTime. I'm no saint either. I gather my superiority complex from looking at a *laptop* all day and applying to jobs. A screen for a serious person.

Playing sports is a haven from screens. I like that people get mad at you if you check your phone instead of taking the ball in from out of bounds. I like that people get mad and intense and frustrated. I like that people give each other tips and talk strategy. I definitely like it when, after 12 missed shot attempts, a three pointer goes in—all net. I like to sweat and talk shit and conduct post-game mortems on the car ride home.

There are important conversations happening about the role technology should or should not play in our lives. People recognize the harmful impacts of social media on mental health and have anxiety about the impact of artificial intelligence on jobs. We're increasingly asking questions about what constitutes humanity and how to protect our own. Technology feels inevitable. And our governance structures to place it in check are woefully outdated and inept.

I want to live in a future where I am reminded of the tremendous shortcomings and the immeasurable capacities of my body. I want to feel things because of interactions I have with people in the world, not an algorithm. I want to play sports. I want you to play sports with me. And I really want my cousin to stop looking at his phone when he's driving.